Kingdom of Saudi Arabia

King Faisal University

College of Computer Sciences & Information Technology

Project Title:

KSA Privacy Policy Analysis Government Application

Course Name:

Professional Responsibility

Group number:6

Name	ID	Contribution
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Walaa Almosabeh	222409691	Methodology to be used to tackle the problem or analyze the issue Road Map Main body Appendix
Atekah Aljafar	222427138	Introduction Background & Context Problem Statement Main body

Submitted to:

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May, 2025

Project REPORT EVALUATION CRITERIA

Criteria	Expected content	Mark contribution
Structure	The report includes all the requirements of Section 3 and Section 4.	/5
A clear and effective Introduction	The Introduction should introduce the reader to the issue definition, background and the methodology to be used to tackle the problem or analyze the issue.	/10
	A road map for the document should be included.	/5
Critical analysis (This is your real contribution)	Clear discussions, comparisons of opinions, and useful analysis highlighting civil, professional and legal and ethical issues.	/15
	Report discusses issues in light of the Saudi laws and legislations which apply to the studied topic.	/15
	Use a "Discussions and Recommendations" section which is to be included in the report before the "Conclusions" section.	/5
Organization	The information provided should be presented in a logical order.	/10
	Report is divided into balanced and justified sections/subsections.	/5
Design	Students should demonstrate good ability of using visual elements with justification like figures, tables, headings, bulleted lists … etc.	/5
Style	This includes correct grammar, spelling and sentence structure.	/10
An effective conclusion	Should include a brief summary of the report content and/or methodology, main discussions and results.	/10
References	Up-to-date relevant references should be provided in APA standard format.	/5
Referencing and citation	Students should provide proper citations of all references, and	/5
	Provide proper referencing of all tables and figures.	/5
Consistency	Appropriate and consistent: • Numbering of pages, sections/subsections, tables, figures, references …etc. • Headings/subheadings font styles and sizes. • Bulleted lists • Tables and figures numbers and captions • Terminology	/10

ABSTRACT

In recent years, Saudi Arabia has undergone rapid digital transformation, driven by its Vision 2030 initiative and the need for efficient public service delivery through digital platforms. This project analyzes the privacy policies of three major Saudi government applications: Tawakkalna, Absher, and Sehhaty. Using the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL) issued by the Saudi Data and Artificial Intelligence Authority (SDAIA) as the primary legal framework, the study applies a comparative content analysis to evaluate these applications in terms of transparency, user rights, and legal compliance. The methodology includes privacy policy collection, framework-based evaluation, and identification of compliance gaps. Results show both strengths and weaknesses in policy clarity, data-sharing transparency, and consent mechanisms. The project concludes with practical recommendations to enhance privacy protections and align with international standards. Ultimately, the study contributes to improving public trust in Saudi digital services and highlights the ethical responsibility of developers in safeguarding user data.

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Chapter 1: Introduction

Digital platforms have become integral to government operations globally, and Saudi Arabia is rapidly advancing in this domain as part of its national digital transformation efforts under Vision 2030. With the growing reliance on mobile apps and online portals to deliver public services, protecting citizens' personal data has become a strategic national priority. This research focuses on assessing the privacy policies of three major Saudi government applications: Tawakkalna, Absher, and Sehhaty. These platforms are essential to the daily lives of citizens and residents—handling services related to health status tracking, civil administration, and medical appointments. The analysis is conducted within the framework of the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL), introduced from Saudi Data and Artificial Intelligence Authority (SDAIA) in 2021 to regulate the collection, use, and protection of personal data in the Kingdom.

1.1 Background and Context

Saudi Arabia's digital evolution has gained strong momentum in the past decade, particularly following the launch of Vision 2030, which emphasizes the creation of a secure and innovative digital government. In line with this transformation, the Saudi Data and Artificial Intelligence Authority (SDAIA) introduced the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL) in 2021, establishing a comprehensive legal framework for the collection, processing, and storage of personal data.

Despite this regulatory progress, recent research highlights a persistent gap between legal standards and practical implementation. For instance, Alhomod and Shafi (2012) found that early e-government websites in Saudi Arabia often lacked complete or

accessible privacy policies, indicating limited alignment with global best practices. More recently, Al-Khalifa et al. (2023) examined a broader range of Saudi digital platforms and uncovered continued weaknesses in transparency, communication of user rights, and enforcement of data protection practices.

These findings point to ongoing challenges faced by Saudi government applications in translating legal requirements into user-centric and effective privacy policies. Addressing these gaps is essential not only for ensuring compliance but also for building public trust in the expanding digital services ecosystem.

1.2 Problem statement

Although Saudi Arabia has established progressive legal frameworks, such as the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL), to safeguard personal data, a significant gap persists between these regulatory standards and the actual practices observed in government applications. Despite the Kingdom's ambitious Vision 2030 goals and the growing reliance on digital platforms to deliver public services, many government applications still either lack comprehensive privacy policies, present them in an inaccessible manner, or omit critical elements that are necessary for user awareness and informed consent.

This gap in privacy policy implementation poses significant risks to citizen trust, legal compliance, and the broader objectives of Saudi Arabia's digital transformation. The inability of government platforms to fully align their privacy policies with both national laws (such as the PDPL) and international best practices undermines public confidence in digital services. Therefore, this study seeks to critically examine the current state of

privacy policies across major Saudi government applications, identify common deficiencies, and propose targeted recommendations to enhance policy effectiveness, user protection, and trust, aligning with both national objectives and international privacy standards.

1.3 Objectives of the Project

The primary objective of this project is to critically evaluate and analyze the privacy policies implemented in Saudi government mobile applications of the category Healthcare and Absher and propose applicable solutions under the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL) issued by the Saudi Data and Artificial Intelligence Authority (SDAIA) in 2021. Specifically, the project aims to identify gaps between current privacy practices in Saudi government applications and the regulatory standards set by the PDPL, assess the robustness of these policies relative to international best practices, and propose practical recommendations to enhance user data protection and transparency in line with SDAIA. Through this analysis, the study seeks to contribute to increasing and strengthening public trust in Saudi digital services and ensuring legal compliance as part of the digital transformation goals of Vision 2030.

1.4 Relevance to Professional responsibility

Professional responsibility is a fundamental concept in the workplace, including the protection of users' personal data in the digital age. Therefore, employees working on Saudi government applications must implement privacy and data protection policies in accordance with the highest ethical standards set forth in the Saudi Personal Data Protection Act of 2021 (SDAIA).

To achieve professional responsibility in personal data privacy, transparency, user consent, and the secure handling of personal information are legal requirements that serve the public interest. These requirements include privacy protection, honesty, and clarity regarding data practices.

Professional responsibility also emphasizes the importance of anticipating and detecting risks early, as well as designing resilient and secure systems that protect personal information from unauthorized access, misuse, or breaches, thereby mitigating these risks. This is even more important in government contexts, where users often have limited options and must trust government platforms to protect their sensitive information.

However, users must be adequately informed about how their data is collected, used, and shared. Therefore, this study's assessment of Saudi government applications is directly linked to assessing the extent to which professionals fulfil their ethical and legal obligations to protect citizens' privacy and build public trust. These are the pillars of professional responsibility and the digital transformation goals of Saudi Vision 2030.

1.5 Methodology used to solve the problem

To effectively tackle the problem of assessing the privacy policies of Saudi government applications, a comparative content analysis approach was adopted, combining legal compliance evaluation with practical usability review.

1. **Application Selection**

   In our study, we selected three prominent Saudi government applications: Tawakkalna, Absher, and Sehhaty. These applications were chosen due to their

widespread use and the sensitive nature of the personal data they handle.

• Tawakkalna: Initially developed to support COVID-19 contact tracing, Tawakkalna has evolved into a comprehensive platform providing various services, including health status updates, digital identification, and access to government services.

• Absher: Managed by the Ministry of Interior, Absher offers a wide range of services such as passport renewals, vehicle registration, and visa applications. It also includes features that have raised privacy concerns, particularly regarding the monitoring of women's travel permissions.

• Sehhaty: Operated by the Ministry of Health, Sehhaty provides health-related services, including appointment scheduling, access to medical records, and COVID-19 test results.

The selection was also informed by prior studies on e-government platforms in Saudi Arabia, such as the case study by Alhomod and Shafi (2012), which highlighted privacy issues across national digital services.

2. **Privacy Policy Collection**

   We gathered the privacy policies from the official interfaces of each application and relevant government platforms, including the Ministry of Interior and the Saudi Press Agency's website, which hosts the SPA's official privacy policy (Saudi Press Agency, n.d.).

3. **Evaluation Framework Creation**

   An evaluation framework was developed using the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL) as a core reference. The law outlines principles like data minimization,

purpose limitation, and informed user consent. To ensure a broader perspective, best practices from the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) were also incorporated. This framework structure was inspired by the official PDPL document published by the Saudi Data and Artificial Intelligence Authority (SDAIA, 2023).

4. **Content Analysis**

   We conducted a detailed review of each privacy policy using this framework, examining how well each app addressed areas like clarity of data collection practices, explanation of user rights, and transparency about data sharing.

5. **Gap Identification**

   The analysis revealed recurring weaknesses such as vague language around how data would be used, insufficient mechanisms for user consent, and little to no information about third-party data sharing. These findings are consistent with the results reported in the Saudi privacy policy dataset study by Al-Khalifa et al. (2023), which documented similar ambiguities in national applications.

6. **Comparative Review**

   We then compared the three applications to identify shared strengths and shortcomings. For instance, all three apps provided some form of consent acknowledgment, but transparency about third-party data sharing remained weak. This stage was guided by general benchmarks found in GOV.SA's Privacy and Data Protection Policy (GOV.SA, n.d.), which helped contextualize our findings within national standards.

7. **Recommendations Development**

   Based on the identified issues, we proposed several actionable recommendations aimed at enhancing privacy protection and compliance. These included clearer user consent prompts, explicit disclosures about data sharing, and alignment with both the PDPL and global norms. The development of these recommendations was guided primarily by the framework established in the PDPL documentation (SDAIA, 2023).

To address this issue, the document first examines the background and context of Saudi Arabia's digital transformation and the increasing focus on data privacy. It then presents a detailed problem statement highlighting the gaps between policy and practical implementation. Following that, the study outlines its objectives and describes the comparative analysis methodology employed to assess current privacy practices. Finally, a comprehensive analysis of the findings is provided, culminating in actionable recommendations to enhance privacy protection and strengthen user trust in Saudi governmental digital services.

Chapter 2: Main Body

2.1 Framework Overview

The primary legal framework guiding this analysis is the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL) of Saudi Arabia, issued in 2021 by the Saudi Data and Artificial Intelligence Authority (SDAIA). The PDPL governs the collection, processing, storage, and sharing of personal data, aiming to ensure the privacy of individuals while enabling trusted data usage. It mandates principles such as purpose limitation, data minimization, user consent, and transparency.

The law applies to all entities—public or private—processing personal data within the Kingdom or involving Saudi residents. In addition to PDPL, the National Data Management Office (NDMO) issues data classification and governance policies that shape how government apps like Tawakkalna, Absher, and Sehaty manage sensitive personal information. This legal infrastructure serves as the benchmark to evaluate the selected apps' privacy practices.

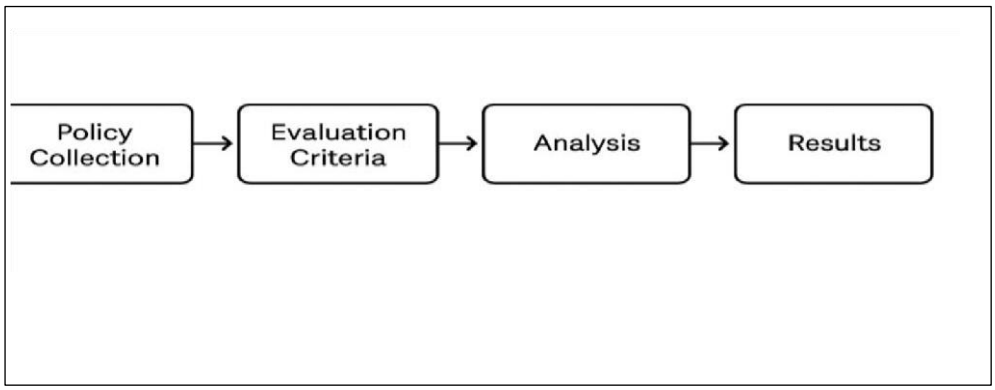

Figure 1: Research Framework Diagram

2.2 Privacy Policy Collection

To conduct the analysis, the privacy policies of Tawakkalna, Absher, and Sehaty applications were reviewed as publicly available on their official platforms or associated websites:

- Tawakkalna (developed by SDAIA): Privacy policy accessed via

  https://ta.sdaia.gov.sa

- Absher (Ministry of Interior): Privacy policy accessed via https://www.absher.sa
- Sehaty (Ministry of Health): Privacy policy accessed via https://www.sehaty.sa

Each policy was examined for compliance with PDPL provisions. Key data points included data collection practices, consent mechanisms, sharing with third parties, data retention policies, user rights, and security measures. Additionally, references were cross-checked with PDPL guidelines and NDMO's data governance framework to ensure consistency and identify any gaps.

2. 3 Strengths and Weaknesses

The table below summarizes the key strengths and weaknesses identified in the privacy practices of three major Saudi government applications—Tawakkalna, Absher, and Sehaty—based on their alignment with the Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL).

Strengths	Weaknesses
Clear statement of the types of data collected (e.g., identity, location, health status, usage behavior).	Lack of detailed retention policies: unclear how long personal data is stored.
Tawakkalna and Absher use user authentication and data encryption, showing compliance with PDPL.	Limited user rights explanation: policies do not fully explain how users can access, correct, or delete their data.
Apps show efforts to obtain user consent, especially Tawakkalna with a structured consent model.	Ambiguity in third-party sharing: especially in Absher, the scope of shared data is unclear.
Increasing transparency in data usage, particularly in Sehaty's latest version regarding third-party sharing.	No Data Protection Officer (DPO) or contact/complaint mechanism clearly stated.

Table 1: Strengths and Weaknesses

2. 4 Ethical Implications

The ethical use of government applications such as **Tawakkalna**, **Sehhaty**, and **Absher** raises critical questions about privacy, consent, and accountability. Although these applications provide essential public services—especially during emergencies like the COVID-19 pandemic—they also involve the processing of highly sensitive personal data.

To evaluate the ethical implications of these platforms, we considered several key dimensions: **informed consent**, **data minimization**, **user autonomy**, and the **existence of accountability mechanisms**. Each application reflects different levels of ethical alignment, as shown in the comparative table below. This comparison highlights gaps and variations in how each app approaches privacy and ethical responsibilities.

Ethical / Legal Criterion	Tawakkalna	Sehhaty	Absher
Clarity of Privacy Policy	Partially clear – legal language is complex	Lacks detail – many aspects not explicitly mentioned	Somewhat detailed – certain clauses are hard to find
Informed Consent	Implied – users consent by using the app	Not explicitly stated	Mandatory for access – no alternative provided
Data Minimization	Collects location and health data – often more than necessary	Collects health-related data only	Collects wide range of personal and service-related data

User Control Over Data	Limited – some features cannot be disabled	No user-access tools for managing personal data	Very limited – no direct user control options available
Accountability and Oversight	Not clear – no DPO or audit body mentioned	No public information about oversight mechanisms	No transparent supervisory body indicated

Table 2: Ethical Implications

Chapter 3: Discussion And Recommendation

3.1 Discussion

The analysis results indicate a clear gap between the requirements of the Saudi Personal Data Protection Law (PDPL) and the actual practices adopted in e-government applications, such as Tawakkalna, Absher, and Sehaty. Despite the inclusion of some privacy policy elements, such as consent notices, the policies often lack full transparency about how data is collected, used, or shared with third parties. Furthermore, the language used in some policies may be technical or ambiguous for the average user, reducing the effectiveness of consent. This lack of clarity and adherence to legal details may reflect a lack of practical application or professional awareness among the developers and implementers of these policies, threatening users' trust in government digital services. Furthermore, comparing these results with international standards such as the European General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) demonstrates that there is significant room for improvement in local policy disclosure and compliance mechanisms to align with global best practices, enhancing cybersecurity and public trust.

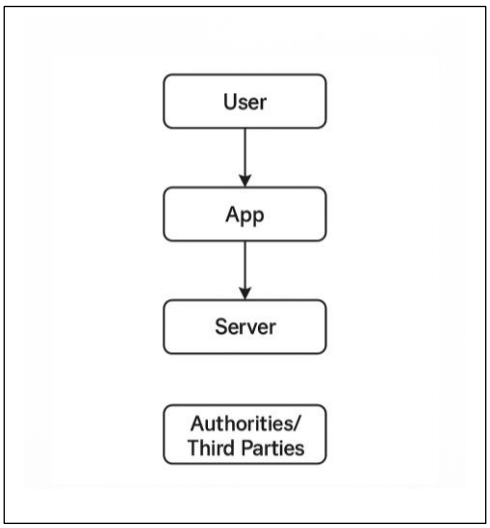

Figure 2: Flow of User Data in Government Apps

3.2 Recommendations / Future Ideas

To strengthen compliance with the Saudi PDPL and enhance ethical standards in the use of personal data, the following actions are recommended for the applications:

- **Simplify and clarify privacy policies** using plain language that is accessible to all users.
- **Implement clear consent mechanisms** that allow users to understand and control what data is collected and how it is used.
- **Apply data minimization principles**, ensuring only necessary data is collected based on the service provided.
- **Designate and disclose Data Protection Officers (DPOs)** to ensure independent oversight and accountability.
- **Provide user-access controls**, allowing individuals to view, modify, or delete their personal data where appropriate.

- **Ensure transparency in handling data breaches** by proactively informing users and authorities.

These measures will not only improve legal compliance but also build greater trust between citizens and government digital services.

Issue Identified	Recommendation
No user data control	Add deletion & edit functions
Forced location tracking	Allow opt-out
Policy is hard to understand	Simplify legal language
Third-party data sharing unclear	Add transparency notice

Table 3: Issues and Recommendations

Chapter 4: Conclusion

In conclusion, the analysis of the privacy policies and ethical considerations surrounding Absher, Tawakkalna, and Sehhaty reveals a pressing need for greater transparency, user autonomy, and accountability in data practices. While these applications serve essential public functions, they must evolve to align with the standards set by the Saudi PDPL and international privacy principles. By adopting the recommendations outlined in this report, these platforms can enhance public trust and ensure responsible data governance in an increasingly digital society.

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Appendix A

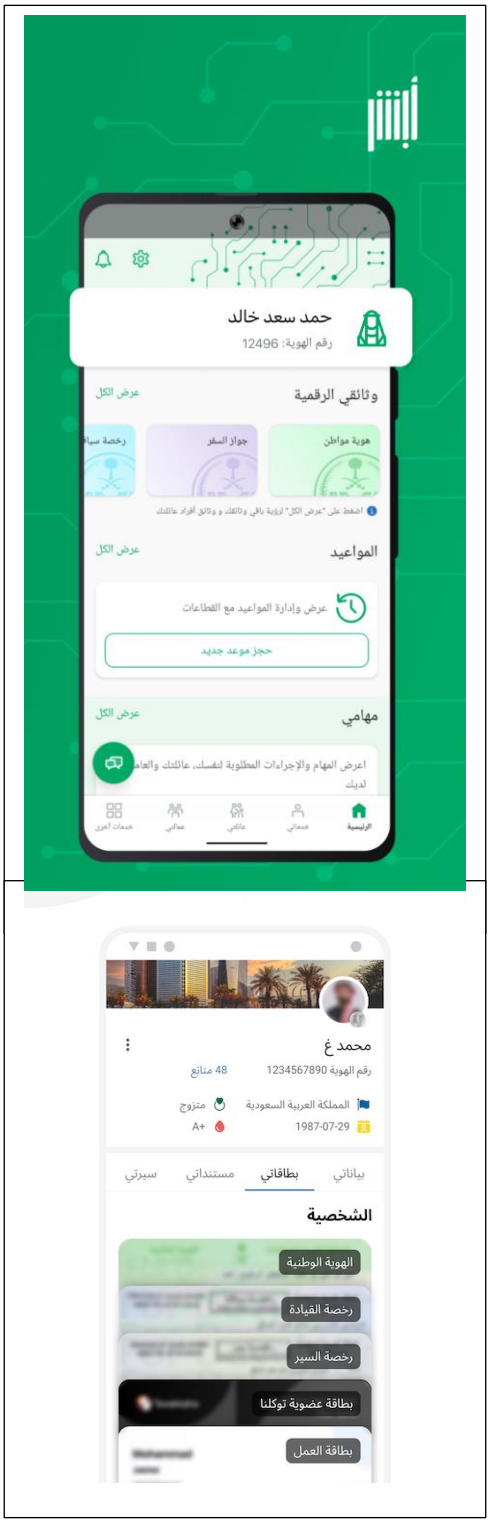

Figure 4: Application Permission Chart